

Averroes



In the 11th and 12th centuries, Avicenna's Neo-Platonist take on Aristotle's ideas was the dominant philosophy of Islam, but it was not without critics. Hard-line theologians such as al-Ghazali saw Aristotelianism as contrary to the Qur'an, but his objections triggered a reaction that ironically strengthened the influence of Aristotle in Islamic philosophy. Al-Ghazali's staunchest opponent was Ibn Rushd (Latinized as Averroes), from Islamic southern Iberia. As well as refuting al-Ghazali's arguments, he dismissed many of Avicenna's Plato-inspired ideas, advocating Aristotle's own far more empirical and rational approach. He argued that there was no incompatibility between religion and philosophy: the Qur'an presents a poetic, metaphorical truth that can be interpreted with philosophical reasoning. However, he believed this should only be done by suitably educated scholars – an idea paradoxically similar to those of Plato. Although his ideas aroused some controversy, translations of his work had a

significant influence on the Christian scholastic philosophy of medieval Europe.